

Notes and rests together

Most music is a mixture of notes and rests. The examples below show how they might be combined in different time signatures. Note how the rests and notes always add up to the correct time value indicated by the time signature.



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◁ Notes and rests in action

Look at these examples and try to hear the rhythm in your head—imagining how the rests contribute to the musical effect. For wind players or singers, the music needs to allow them spaces to breathe. Rests are a common way of achieving this.

Dotted rests

Just like notes, rests of all time values can also be dotted, making them one-and-a-half times as long. Two examples, a dotted quarter note rest and a dotted eighth note rest, are shown here.



△ Dotted quarter note rest

The dotted quarter note rest has a time value of $1\frac{1}{2}$ quarter notes, the same as a quarter note plus an eighth note.



△ Dotted eighth note rest

The time value of a dotted eighth note rest is $1\frac{1}{2}$ eighth notes, the same as a eighth note plus a sixteenth note.

Ties

Two notes can be joined by a tie to make a single, longer note. Joining notes serves various purposes—a composer may want a note that cannot be represented by a single time value, or a very long note that goes across several measures. Sometimes the rhythm is easier to read using a tie than it is by having a single note that crosses a beat.



◁ A single longer note

The half note is tied to the eighth note, making a single longer note. Its time value cannot be represented by a single note, so a tie is used.



◁ Across a bar line

Ties are often used to join notes across a bar line. The notes and rests within a measure must never exceed the time value of the measure.



◁ Adding tied notes

Several tied notes can be added together to achieve the desired length of a note.